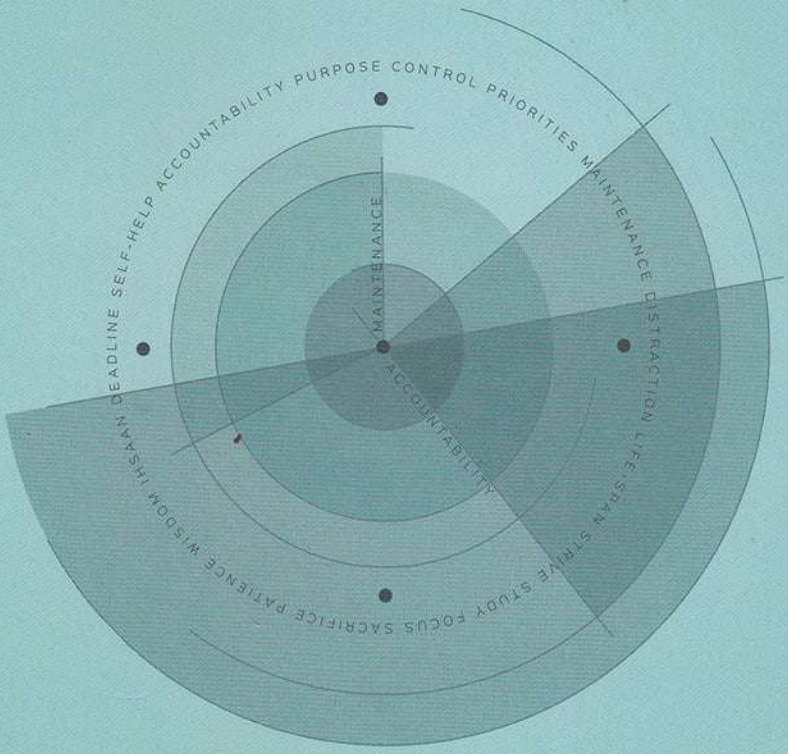
TIME MANAGEMENT



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SEAN PUBLICATION

AMOL BOOKS

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The First Step
Living with a Purpose

أَفَحَسِبْتُمْ أَنَّمَا خَلَقْنَاكُمْ عَبَثًا وَأَنَّكُمْ إِلَيْنَا لَا تُرْجَعُونَ

"Do you think that We had created you in play (without any purpose), and that you would not be brought back to Us?" (Surah Al-Muminoon 23:115)

The primary motive for wanting to manage time is having goals which require the management of time. It is here that many people fail. Many of us go through life without any goals or purpose. We drone on through day after day, going through the motions of life with a sense of fear, anxiety and boredom. To fill this void, we surround ourselves with a lot of entertainment to drown out the voice of our souls so that we are distracted from thinking, and so that we are killing time.

For a Muslim, this is a sign of not understanding a basic fundamental of our religion i.e. we were created for a purpose and this world is just a testing ground to see who will live up to that purpose and who will not.

وَمَا خَلَقْتُ الْجِنَّ وَالْإِنْسَ إِلَّا لِيَعْبُدُونِ

"And I did not create Jinn and Humans except to worship me," (Surah Adh-Dhariyat 51:56)

The purpose of life is to worship Allah as stated in this verse. This is agreed upon and accepted by all Muslims, but where we fail is in understanding how to transform that purpose from theory into practical reality.

This lies in understanding what worshipping Allah means, and how we can fulfil that. The Islamic definition of worship

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is servitude i.e. to obey and serve Allah. So our goal is not to engage 24/7 in acts of worship, but rather to live our lives in accordance to the teachings of Islam. What are some of these teachings that relate directly to time management?

1. Muslims must strive to benefit humanity.

One of the primary methods in which we can serve Allah is by taking care of His Creation. There are many ways in which we can benefit the creation of Allah, be it through teaching, counselling, medical practice, humanitarian efforts or just giving someone hope and happiness.

In order to practice this, you need to identify something you are passionate about that can benefit others, then to manage your time around fulfilling that goal. In that way, you are now living with a purpose, worshipping Allah through benefitting His Creation and representing Him on earth.

2. Muslims must propagate the message of Islam to others.

Dawah is a fundamental of our religion and each of us can contribute to it by being good Muslims so that people can see Islam in our actions, and by educating our friends, co-workers and families about Islam. When Dawah becomes a fundamental part of your life, you have yet another purpose to work towards and another reason to manage your time well.

3. We must study and understand Islam in order to obey Allah properly.

It is not possible to live a life of obedience to Allah if we do not know the laws of Allah. Therefore, it is obligatory upon Muslims to learn Islam and work towards a gradual increase in beneficial knowledge. If continuous progress in seeking Islamic knowledge becomes a fundamental part of your life, then you

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have yet another purpose and reason around which to manage your time.

This shows us how directly linked time management is to being a Muslim.

In fact, when we look at the acts of worship in Islam, many of the ritual Ibaadah in Islam are time-bound acts of worship.

For example, Salah is prayed five times a day at specific times. The habit of praying five times a day naturally creates a sense of time management in an individual, if done properly. Fasting is at a specific month of the year, as is Hajj, both help us keep track of which month of the year it is. Zakah is an annual thing, which is once again related to time.

Time seems to factor into every major part of our religion, and therefore in order to live fulfilling lives, we need to manage our time properly.

Understanding our purpose in life and setting particular goals to help you live up to that purpose is the fundamental first step towards time well-managed.

Formulating Life Goals

Once you recognize the purpose of life, the next step to effective time management is to formulate personal goals that assist you in fulfilling your purpose. These goals should be such that they align your natural talents, passions and skills with the purpose of life, creating a path through life which you are passionate about, and at the same time which is pleasing to Allah.

Goal-setting is very empowering. People who have clear goals wake up earlier and full of energy, ready and excited to tackle the next day. They feel happier and more fulfilled because their

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lives have direction. They feel more confident because they are working towards something greater.

The goals you set should utilize your skills but more importantly, they must be pleasing to Allah. For example, if you are a skilled writer then make it your goal in life to write beneficial books or articles. If you are passionate about business, make it your goal in life to set up businesses that benefit people and provide value to their lives. If you enjoy being around children, consider teaching as a profession. Find your skill and choose a noble goal that you can pursue with that skill.

Once you have goals, life changes. Everything becomes focused and purposeful. Each day has an objective and you have a reason to wake up and pursue your daily goals and tasks. This one huge change in one's life creates a higher level of confidence as your life is driven and purposeful.

A worthy goal is something that seems impractical to pessimists, yet attainable to optimists. It is something long term that cannot be accomplished overnight. It requires foresight, visualization and the ability to see optimistically into the distant future. It is something that you will need to dedicate years of your life towards before seeing the fruit of it. Despite all this, it is something worth dedicating your life to and the end result is worth all the effort and patience.

Most Self-Help books offer the S.M.A.R.T. formula for goal setting as this formula is simple, yet effective. It covers the five main criteria to consider when setting a goal, so we will utilize the same model here.

A S.M.A.R.T. goal refers to a goal that is:

Specific – This means that your goal shouldn't be something vague. It should be something specific that you want to work

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towards. "I want to be an author" is a vague goal, but "I want to write a book about self-confidence from an Islamic perspective" is a very specific goal.

Measurable – This means that your goal should be something you can keep track of to measure how close you are to completing your goal. Goals are generally long term projects and without any form of measurement, it is difficult to know whether you are closer to accomplishing it or not. An example of a measurable goal is setting a goal to write one hundred pages a month by writing three and half pages a day.

Attainable – This means your goal should be something you can work towards and attain. If your goal is to build a multi-million dollar Islamic Centre and you don't have the resources to do so, then this is not an attainable goal and should either be left for later in life or tweaked to become more attainable.

Realistic – This means your goal must be something you have the ability to do and something you are willing to do. If you hate writing, then making it a goal to write a 500 page book is not realistic, even though it is attainable. Being realistic means knowing what you are good at, what you are willing to sacrifice for, and making your goals in line with that.

Timely – Finally, a goal must have a time limit. As long as you leave something without any time limit, you will not feel the urgency to work on it. Saying that "Someday I want to write a 300 page book" is not going to help you write it. Setting a goal to write the book within three months by writing four pages a day is a timely goal, and creates the sense of urgency needed to get things done.

These five qualities help us make our goals achievable by creating the kind of description, pattern and system necessary to make sure we get it done. When setting your goals, weigh

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each goal in light of all five criterion to fine-tune it until you have a concrete plan to work with.

Once you have a S.M.A.R.T. goal, you now have something concrete to manage your time around. For example, if your goal is to write a book, then you will now have to dedicate an hour a day to writing three pages a day. This fits right in with effective time management as you now know exactly what you want to accomplish and your daily tasks are working towards these larger goals, instead of just keeping you busy.

Focusing on Allah

In his book "the Seven Habits of Highly Effective People" Stephen Covey talks about the different centres that people have in their lives which includes money, family, spouse and friends and he recommends that people should centre their lives around principles as this will make them more effective. There is no doubt that living a principle centred life is more effective than the above mentioned things. However, the one flaw in this theory is in who decides on what principles one should centre one's life around?

Without a set basis, anything can become a principle and sometimes wrong things are justified because they agree with people's principles. For example, homosexuality is accepted based on the principle of freedom while polygamy is not. Yet if the principle of religion is applied, it would be the other way round. This raises the question: Who decides on which principles are worth revolving one's life around?

This is why I propose an alternative, an Allah-centred life. By choosing to revolve our lives around Allah and His Laws we are living principle-centred lives, but these principles are not conjured by our imaginations. Rather they are divinely revealed

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